15 CHANNELS · HOW TO START EACH

THE $1M ARR CHANNEL MAP

Every channel B2B startups use to get from zero to $1M ARR, with what each one costs, how fast it moves, and the three things to do this week to get it going.

WHAT THIS IS

I'm a partner at RallyUp. We pivoted to an agency on 1 May 2026 with almost nothing, and we've grown every month since.

I wish we'd had this map on day one. It covers fifteen channels, and for each you get what it is, how fast it moves, what it costs, three first steps and the mistake that usually kills it.

> **The honest promise.** Founders who reach $1M ARR almost always get there on two or three channels, worked properly for a long time, so the real job is picking yours. The speed and cost labels are my rules of thumb from running these for founders. Nobody measured them as benchmarks.

HOW TO PICK YOUR TWO

1. **Need customers this month?** Start with warm intros, founder dinners or newsletter ads, because they're fast and cheap to test.
2. **Building for next year?** Add one compounding channel: founder-led content, building in public, programmatic SEO or GEO.
3. **Give each one 90 days** before you judge it, and count customers when you do. Attention doesn't pay anyone.

THE 15 CHANNELS

01

Programmatic SEO

SPEED: SLOW, THEN COMPOUNDING · COST: TIME, PLUS A LITTLE DEV WORK

Hundreds of search pages built from one template and a dataset, each answering a narrow query: "[tool] alternatives", "[tool] + [tool] integration", "[job] salary in [city]".

Start this week

1. List 50 queries your buyers type that follow one pattern, then check each in a keyword tool for real search volume.
2. Build one page by hand and make it genuinely useful. If you wouldn't read it, Google won't rank it.
3. Template it and publish 20, then wait 6 to 8 weeks before you publish 200.

Watch out: Google de-indexes thin pages, so every page needs data or an answer a reader can't get anywhere else.

02

Channel partners

SPEED: MEDIUM · COST: REVENUE SHARE, USUALLY 10 TO 30%

Companies that already sell to your buyer resell or refer you: agencies, consultancies, resellers, implementation partners.

Start this week

1. Write down who your customers already pay before they find you. Those are your partners.
2. Offer three of them a revenue share and close the first deal alongside them.
3. Give partners a one-page pitch and a demo account, then hold one call a month.

Watch out: Partners sell whatever is easiest. If your product needs explaining, they won't push it until you've shown them it sells.

03

App marketplaces

SPEED: MEDIUM · COST: INTEGRATION BUILD TIME

Listing inside the platforms your buyers already use: Slack, HubSpot, Salesforce, Shopify, Zapier, Chrome.

Start this week

1. Pick the one platform most of your customers already live in.
2. Ship the smallest integration that's useful on day one, and write the listing around the job it does.
3. Ask your first 10 users for a review, since marketplace ranking leans heavily on them.

Watch out: You're building on someone else's platform, and they can change the rules, the ranking or the API whenever they like.

04

Newsletter ads

SPEED: FAST · COST: FROM A FEW HUNDRED DOLLARS A SLOT

Buying a sponsored slot in a newsletter your buyers already read.

Start this week

1. Ask five customers which newsletters they actually open, and buy from that list rather than a directory.
2. Start small: one newsletter, one placement, one offer. A free resource beats "book a demo".
3. Track it with a dedicated link and judge it on signups. Clicks tell you very little.

Watch out: One send tells you almost nothing. Buy two or three in the same newsletter before you decide.

05

Generative engine optimization (GEO)

SPEED: SLOW · COST: TIME

Getting cited when people ask ChatGPT, Claude, Perplexity or Gemini for a recommendation in your category.

Start this week

1. Ask the assistants the five questions your buyers ask. Note who gets recommended and which pages they cite.
2. Get yourself onto those sources: comparison pages, Reddit threads, reviews, "best tools for" lists.
3. Publish pages that answer one question clearly, with facts an assistant can quote.

Watch out: It's hard to measure, so add "how did you hear about us" to signup and count the AI answers.

06

Founder dinners

SPEED: FAST · COST: DINNER FOR 10, PLUS YOUR TIME

A small dinner for 8 to 12 of your ideal customers, on a topic they care about. You host and you don't pitch.

Start this week

1. Pick a topic your buyers argue about and make that the invitation.
2. Invite 30 to get 10. Ask one respected guest first, then name them in the other invites.
3. The next day, send a thank-you note and a summary of the conversation, and nothing else.

Watch out: Pitch at the table and you lose the room. The dinner earns you a meeting, and the meeting is where you sell.

07

Affiliates

SPEED: MEDIUM · COST: COMMISSION ON REVENUE

Paying people a commission for every customer they send you: creators, consultants, existing customers.

Start this week

1. Ask the customers who already recommend you before anyone else.
2. Offer a commission big enough to notice, and pay it on time, every time.
3. Give affiliates swipe copy, a demo video and their own tracked link.

Watch out: Most affiliates send nothing and a handful send almost everything, so recruit for the handful.

08

Reddit marketing

SPEED: MEDIUM · COST: TIME

Being useful in the subreddits your buyers use, as a person, until people start asking what you're building.

Start this week

1. Find the five subreddits where your buyers ask for help, and read each one's rules.
2. Answer questions properly for two weeks before you mention your product once.
3. When you do post, lead with the lesson rather than a link, and say that you built the thing.

Watch out: Reddit spots marketing fast, and a ban happens in public. Be a member first.

09

Referral programs

SPEED: MEDIUM · COST: THE REWARD

Rewarding customers for bringing other customers.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Wait until customers already refer you without being asked. A program amplifies referrals that are happening anyway; it can't start them.
> 2. Reward both sides, with something they'd actually want.
> 3. Ask at the happiest moment, right after a win. Day one is too early.

> **Watch out:** If nobody refers you today, fix the product before you build a program.

10

Building in public

SPEED: SLOW, THEN COMPOUNDING · COST: TIME, AND SOME NERVE

Sharing your real numbers, decisions and mistakes as you go, so people follow the company before they need it.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Pick the numbers you'll share every week and keep the format fixed.
> 2. Share the decisions and the mistakes along with the wins, because the misses are what people trust.
> 3. End every post with one clear next step: the newsletter, the waitlist or the product.

> **Watch out:** Decide what stays private (client names, contract values) before the first post. Afterwards is too late.

11

Influencer marketing

SPEED: FAST · COST: PER POST, VARIES WIDELY

Paying creators your buyers already follow to post about you.

Start this week

1. Pick creators by who follows them rather than how many do, and ask for an audience breakdown.
2. Brief them on the problem and let them write it in their own voice.
3. Pay for one test post before you buy a package, and track it with their own link.

Watch out: Views are easy to buy and customers aren't. One launch can pull millions of views and almost no users.

12

A big launch day

SPEED: FAST · COST: TIME AND FAVOURS

Concentrating everything into one day, with the founder's post, the team, customers, investors and partners all sharing at once.

Start this week

1. Four days before, line up 50 people who'll comment in the first hour.
2. Give the post two asks, a comment and the link, because they're separate funnels.
3. Plan the second post now. It's often the one that converts.

Watch out: Most of the result arrives in the days after, so plan that week as carefully as the morning of.

13

Founder-led content on LinkedIn

SPEED: SLOW, THEN COMPOUNDING · COST: TIME, OR A GHOSTWRITER

The founder posts several times a week about the problem, the customers and the company, so buyers know them before they need them.

Start this week

1. Write down 10 things you've seen that your buyers haven't. Those are your first 10 posts.
2. Post three times a week for 90 days before you judge it.
3. Grade each post on saves, profile views and DMs. Reach will mislead you.

Watch out: Reach is the wrong scoreboard. A post with huge reach can bring seven followers and no signups.

14

Paid ads

SPEED: FAST · COST: AD SPEND, PLUS TESTING BUDGET

Buying reach on Google, LinkedIn, Meta or Reddit and paying per click or per thousand views.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. Start with search ads on the terms people type when they already want what you sell.
> 2. Send the ads to a page with one offer and one form.
> 3. Set a test budget you can afford to lose, and kill anything that hasn't produced a customer by the time it's spent.

> **Watch out:** Ads multiply whatever already converts. A page that doesn't convert organically just gets more expensive.

15

Warm intros through your network

SPEED: FAST · COST: FAVOURS

Asking people who know you to introduce you to people who could buy.

> **Start this week**
>
> 1. List 50 people who'd take your call, and next to each, write two people they know that you'd like to meet.
> 2. Write the intro for them: three lines they can forward unchanged.
> 3. Report back after every intro, whatever happened. That's how you get the next one.

> **Watch out:** Your network runs out. Use it for your first customers while you build a channel that won't.

THE ONE PAGE VERSION

1. Pick one fast channel and one compounding channel, and ignore the other thirteen for 90 days.
2. Before you pick, ask five buyers where they already spend their time.
3. Judge every channel on customers. Views don't count.
4. Start where you have an unfair advantage, like a network, an audience or a platform your buyers live in.
5. Anything built on someone else's platform can be taken away, so own the email list.

Francisco Gost writes The Draft, a weekly letter on how top 1% startups crush organic marketing, at franciscogost.com

Partner at RallyUp. 21.3M+ impressions generated for B2B founders and execs.